among others—were fiercely independent and acted as a buffer between Tibet and Assam. The fact that these tribes inhabited the dense jungles south of the Himalayan crest line meant that the Tibetans had very little to do with them. The Chinese, needless to say, were nowhere in the picture.

Even Tawang, over which Tibet claimed sovereignty until 1914, was an independent country that was de facto under the control of the lamas and the monks of the Tawang Monastery. It was only towards the latter half of the nineteenth century that Lhasan authorities began to assert their influence over the region and deputed dzongpens to govern the region. Like the Khampa in the Kham province of Tibet bordering China, the Monpa and the Sherdukpen too were caught between the tyranny of the monks and the Tibetan officials. The latter in particular were locally referred to as zakpas meaning ‘the plunderers’.

The Tawang belt—better known as the Kameng Frontier Division—ran between Bhutan on the west and the Miji, Aka and Abor (Nyishi) dominated jungles to the east. The northern frontier of this region belt is geographically and culturally separated from Tibet by the Kangto (also known as Sher Kangri) and Gaurichen massif. The crest line also acts as a watershed between the Tsangpo and the Kameng River catchments. Further to its east lies the Bokar region that extends up to the upper reaches of the Subansiri River. So wild and inhospitable was this area that Tibetans on the northern side did not venture across the watershed even for trade.

Between the Subansiri headwaters and the Dibang River catchment lies the main Siang River Valley. The east flowing Tsangpo, after taking a bend to the south, flowed into Abor (Adi) territory. At this point, the Siang Valley is at a considerably lower altitude when compared to the flanking catchments of the Subansiri and the Dibang rivers. This was the natural gateway for trade, but once again the highly aggressive and hostile tribes that inhabited the Assam Himalayas kept the Tibetans away. In fact, even some of the immediate areas on the northern side of the watershed—for example Chumbi that bordered Bhutan and Sikkim and Po-yul that bordered the Mishmi lands to the south—were not under Lhasa or Peking, and considered themselves to be independent kingdoms. The rest of the region was, however, clearly part of Tibet and was governed by dzongpens who operated from their fortified forts (dzongs).

The Po-yul region to the east of the Tsangpo’s great bend consisted of two distinct sub-regions: Po-teu and Po-me. The former was bleak country